EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Will We Know Our Loved Ones When the Dead Rise?

Given Monday 26 May 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 7:7-8

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 7 (The Resurrection of the Dead), Chapter 7 and Chapter 8 (Questions 1 to 6)

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 26 May 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Saadia's Thesis So Far

Two chapters of the essay remain, plus a very short ninth chapter that is really a conclusion. Next week is Shavuot, with no shiur. After that, a shiur on the different views of *techiyat hametim* in the Rishonim, "three main different ways to understand" it, since "the permutations of how and when and the details of techiyat hametim are quite different."

So far Saadia has answered the challenges from **nature** and from **logic**, setting out when we may read Tanach non-literally; answered the **verses** that seem to deny resurrection; and brought the explicit verses that affirm it: Yechezkel, Yeshayahu, Daniel, and Ha'azinu in the Torah itself.

The Rabbi looked ahead to Essay 9. There Saadia is the first to ask why Olam HaBa is not explicitly mentioned in Tanach: there are many hints in the Gemara, but nothing explicit. "But techiyat hametim is black and white in the Torah."

Saadia's thesis, then, is **two resurrections**:

- **During the days of Mashiach, in this world**, "whilst we're still eating and drinking and marrying… and living the life of this world." Reserved for Am Yisrael.
- **When the world to come begins**: a second resurrection for all the righteous of the world.

There are sources in the Gemara, the Rabbi noted, for two such stages.

Chapter 7: The Chachamim

The fourth avenue: is there anything in rabbinic tradition against resurrection? Saadia says no: **דבריהם ז"ל מלאים מזכרה וסיפורה**, their words are full of it.

(A textual note: the printed text reads "the tradition of the prophets and the tradition of the Chachamim," but the Rabbi said those words are not in the old prints. The prophets belong to

the third avenue, Scripture; this avenue is rabbinic tradition.)

Saadia mentions only "a few" as a souvenir, because there are so many. The Gemara records **kings and queens** asking the Chachamim about it, such as **Cleopatra**, who asked whether the dead will rise clothed or unclothed, and our own people asked too, and the Chachamim answered each. Saadia brings four statements.

1. Seven shepherds and eight princes

Saadia opens with **הנני שלח לכם את אליה הנביא**, I am sending you Eliyahu, which he connects to Mashiach, and the verse in **Michah**: **והקמנו עליו שבעה רעים ושמנה נסיכי אדם**, we will raise up against him seven shepherds and eight princes of men.

Who are they? The **Gemara in Sukkah** answers, in Saadia's text:

- **Seven shepherds:** David in the middle; **Shet and Metushelach** on his right; **Avraham, Yitzchak, Yaakov and Moshe** on his left.
- **Eight princes: Yishai, Shaul, Shmuel, Amos, Tzefaniah, Chizkiyahu, Eliyahu and Mashiach**.

Saadia concludes: **הנה אמרו בפירוש שהמתים יעמדו בימי הישועה**, they said explicitly that the dead will rise in the days of the salvation. And since Mashiach is one of the eight princes, Mashiach and resurrection "go hand in hand." That is his point: not just that the Chachamim speak of resurrection, but that it comes **with the redemption**. "We'll see our shepherds, we'll see Avraham, Yitzchak, Yaakov, and we'll see our princes, we'll see the prophets."

Textual variants. "Just in case you're wondering": the **Ben Ish Chai** already asks why Shet and Metushelach are on the right and the Avot on the left. And our Gemara's text differs: **Adam, Shet and Metushelach** on the right, and **Avraham, Yaakov and Moshe** on the left. Yitzchak is missing, and **Rashi** brings a Midrash that Yitzchak went to save his children from Gehinnom. The texts vary on whether the list includes Yitzchak or Adam, but the main point stands.

2. The seven years of Gog

מי שימות בשבע שני גוג לא יעמוד בתחיית המתים: whoever dies in the seven years of Gog will not rise. The war of Gog and Magog is "a whole other discussion," but it is certainly a prelude to the days of Mashiach: seven years of chaos and upheaval. "We're not entirely sure who this Gog is. Whenever there's some attack on Israel, everyone rushes to identify Gog as the enemy," sometimes Iran.

The Gemara's analogy: before a wedding there is a reception, "a drinks party." If you are invited to the drinks party, you will be invited to the wedding; if not, not. So Rabbi Yonah said: whoever dies in the seven years of Gog will not merit to see Mashiach. **וסימנך דאכיל פרפרא אכיל סעודתא**: whoever eats the appetiser eats the feast.

3. Whoever denies resurrection

מי שכפר בתחיית המתים לא יחיה לימות המשיח, even if his deeds are good. This is **measure for measure**: if you do not believe in something, how can it be given to you?

Saadia quotes the **Gemara in Sanhedrin**, which brings a proof from **the officer of Yehoram ben Achav**. In the famine, Elisha announced that tomorrow there would be plenty of food. The king's aide, on whose arm the king leaned, scoffed: even if Hashem opened windows in the

heavens, could this be? Elisha answered: **הנך ראה בעיניך ומשם לא תאכל**, you will see it with your own eyes, but you will not eat of it. And so it was. Because he denied Elisha's words, he saw it and did not enjoy it. So too, whoever denies resurrection will not take part in it, **שכל מדותיו של הקדוש ברוך הוא מדה כנגד מדה**. Hence the Mishnah: **כל ישראל יש להם חלק לעולם הבא**, except one who denies *techiyat hametim*.

"If you deny it, you can't be part of it. Nothing I can do about that." The Rabbi applied the same logic to a question people ask: will a good, moral person who does not believe in Hashem have Olam HaBa? "The answer is no... Yes, he's a great person, he's a moral person and everything. But reality is you don't believe in the world to come, so how can you have a portion in the world to come? ... It's not part of your identity."

4. Rising in their shrouds

> **המתים יעמדו בתכריכיהם**: the dead will rise in their shrouds, and the **tzaddikim in their own clothes**. If you wonder how, it is no harder for Hashem to restore their clothes than their bodies.

When this spread among the masses, people began to go to great lengths over their burial clothes: "I want to get the best clothes, so that when I'm resurrected I'll stand up in my fine tuxedo." It became a great evil: those who could not afford what their dead had demanded would not bury them, and the burden fell on the community. Until **Rabban Gamliel** decreed that he himself be buried in two simple linen garments, and everyone followed. To this day, men and women, wealthy or poor, are buried in the same white linen shrouds.

Questions on Chapter 7

When was this? Over 1,900 years ago: Rabban Gamliel lived in the 1st century. As head of the Sanhedrin he said, I will be buried in simple white shrouds, and "I don't know any Jewish community which doesn't bury in white shrouds."

Will people long dead rise in shrouds that have rotted away? "If Hashem can bring back the body, says Saadia, He can bring back your shrouds as well. Once you get out in your shrouds, then you'll run home and get your best clothes again."

With flesh, or like a ghost in a shroud? With flesh, the Rabbi imagined, "because they're going to be normal human beings for a period of time... who eat, who drink, who marry, have children," and for that you need flesh.

Flora said she had always thought Rabban Gamliel's decree was simply about expensive coffins and clothes and making everyone equal. "No, the Gemara says this": people would not bury their loved ones because of wills demanding the finest clothes.

What Saadia sees in these sources

All four show rabbinic support for resurrection, "but more importantly for Saadia," the first shows it comes **together with Mashiach**. His sequence: **seven years of upheaval, Mashiach, resurrection for Am Yisrael**; life continues to an extent, with marriage, children, the service of Hashem and free will; and then the move to Olam HaBa.

Chapter 8: Ten Questions

Having established all this, Saadia turns to the **consequences** of the belief: ten questions people ask, answered from Scripture, logic and tradition. "Some are very interesting." Tonight covered six.

Question 1: Who will be resurrected?

כל צדיק ובעל תשובה: every righteous person, and anyone who lived wickedly but repented. Only those who die wicked without teshuvah will not rise, "and that makes sense logically," since Scripture promises many times that Hashem accepts those who return.

The Rabbi recalled the famous **Gemara** on the levels of atonement, touched on earlier in this series. For a positive commandment neglected, teshuvah alone; for a negative prohibition, teshuvah and Yom Kippur; for a prohibition carrying the death penalty, Yom Kippur and some suffering too; and for **chillul Hashem**, death. Saadia then brings a teaching that one might have thought even death would not atone, and the verse **הנה אני פתח את קברותיכם** teaches that even one who did the worst sins, if he repented and died, will be resurrected. **וזה הנה חייבת תחיית המתים לכל השב**: resurrection is assured for every penitent.

ואני אומר כמעט הם מבני עמנו שמתים בבלי תשובה: very few of our people die without teshuvah. The **Ramchal** writes the same "black and white" in Derech Hashem: very few will not have Olam HaBa. And Saadia stresses again that this resurrection is for the Jewish people, for those who suffered in exile.

Must you be buried in Israel?

Saadia never says that resurrection is only for those in Eretz Yisrael. Why do so many people who lived and died abroad want to be buried there? Because of the **Gemara in Ketubot**, where **Rabbi Elazar** says that those who die outside the Land will not be resurrected. But the Gemara answers that those buried outside will roll through underground tunnels, **מחילות**, to Israel. "Whether that's literal or not, I don't know. I can't imagine it is."

The Rabbi added that taking bodies to Israel raises a halachic complication: a dead body is *tamei*, so what gives you the right to bring impurity into the Land? That is why many tzaddikim who lived with their communities in the diaspora asked to be buried there. "That's a whole discussion." Saadia's own view, as Question 3 will show, is that the resurrection takes place in the whole world.

Question 2: Will they die again?

כי לא ימותו: no. **אבל מעתיקים אותם מימות המשיח אל נעימות עולם הבא**: they are transferred from the days of Mashiach to the delight of Olam HaBa. As the Chachamim said, the dead whom Hashem revives do not return to their dust.

A digression: what kind of body? For Saadia, the ultimate world to come, after Gog, after Eliyahu, after Mashiach and the resurrection, is **body and soul together**, because the body took part in the service of this world and must benefit. Yet the Gemara says, undisputed, **העולם הבא אין בו לא אכילה ולא שתיה** and no marital relations. So what is the body for?

It will be **an elevated body**, like **Moshe Rabbeinu's**. Moshe ate, drank, had a wife and children; yet three times he spent forty days on high learning Torah, without eating or drinking. He still

had his body, but it was elevated. Our bodies now are essentially animal bodies, "we are mammals," with impulses we learn to control. In Olam HaBa there will be no impulses.

So in Saadia's sequence, you rise in this world with your normal desires and enjoy this life, "however long it is." Then you do not die again: at the end of this world you are transferred, "how? I've got no idea," into the new world, living for eternity in "a Moshe Rabbeinu kind of body."

Q: What's the use of a body that has nothing to do? "That's a very good question, which is why the Rambam denies" any body in Olam HaBa: for him it is consciousness alone, for exactly that reason. Saadia, and many after him, felt it would be unfair for the body to toil for 120 years alongside the soul and receive no reward. On Yom Kippur your body wants to eat and your mind says no; "that body worked, it suffered, so how are you going to compensate and remunerate that body?"

Q: Maybe it's an AI body, a robot? "Who knows? Could be." Flora objected that a robot is not truly alive. "No, actually it makes total sense." The **Ramchal**, as those who learned Da'at Tevunot with him years ago will remember, says something very similar. Now we have urges for good from the soul and for bad from the body, in constant battle; even the greatest tzaddik who never sinned still has the animal urge within him. In Olam HaBa there are levels: first the urge is held in check, as Moshe's bodily needs were **suspended** for those forty days; and then a higher level where the body is entirely subjugated to the soul. "The body just tags along... It just follows whatever the soul wants... which is what we would nowadays call a robot."

Houses and furniture? In the first resurrection, in this world, certainly: "You'll continue living in your houses." In the world to come, "no idea." What will we do there? "In short, you bask in the divine presence." Where is that world? Saadia follows the Gemara of 6,000 years, then a thousand years of desolation, then the new world; the Rambam does not take that Gemara as final. "Who knows? No one can tell you the answer." And that new world will include all the pious of the nations, who do not take part in the first resurrection.

Question 3: Will the land hold them all?

The Rabbi noted that the **Rambam** mentions some of these questions, how will it look, will I rise in my clothes, with my blemishes, and his answer is: don't spend your time on them, you'll see when it happens. "And the Rambam has a very strong point... How does it help to know now?" But Saadia felt it right to answer them.

Saadia's calculation, for the resurrection in this world, which is for the Jewish people:

- About **2,200 years** since the nation was formed, in Saadia's day.
- That is about **32 generations**.
- Each generation about **1.2 million**: the Torah counts 600,000 men leaving Egypt, so double it for men and women.
- 1.2 million times 32 is **38.4 million** people.
- Even giving each person **more than 200 *amot***, about 100 metres, "for his plants, for his animal, for his car," they would occupy less than **1/150th** of the earth.

He works through *parsah*, *mil* and *amah*: "To be honest, I didn't fully understand it, it's quite complex." The conclusion: "don't bother worrying about that. There will be plenty space for everyone."

The Rabbi drew two inferences. This calculation is a proof that the first resurrection is **only for Israel**, since he counts only Bnei Yisrael. And since he measures against **the whole earth**, Saadia clearly holds that it happens throughout the world, not only in Eretz Yisrael.

What about skyscrapers? "You're right actually... He's very clever. With skyscrapers there'll be much more space." Maybe we'll all fit in Israel: "That's why Tel Aviv has so many skyscrapers."

Question 4: Will they recognise their families?

"This is a question people love asking when they lose a loved one." The Rambam would say: we'll find out. Saadia says **yes**. His proof is the Gemara of the shepherds and princes: to see them and appreciate that they are our shepherds, Moshe and David and Yishai, we will have to know who they are. And Yechezkel describes the land divided tribe by tribe, so we will know our tribe and our people. Just as we will know them, we will surely know our loved ones, living together in the same tribes.

"Provided, of course, your family gets resurrected." It is possible that a husband will be resurrected and his wife not, or vice versa, "however unpleasant that may seem and sound."

Question 5: Will the blind and the maimed rise with their defects?

Yes, at first: **שיחיה תחילה במומו כדי שיכירו בני אדם שהוא הוא**, he will first rise with his defect so that people recognise him. **ואחר כן ירפאהו הבורא**: then the Creator will heal him completely. The Gemara in **Sanhedrin** says the same: **עומדים במומן ומתרפאין**. Hence Ha'azinu: **אני אמית ואחיה מחצתי ואני ארפא**: first I bring to life, and then I heal the wounds.

"If a person lived this world without legs and then he gets up walking around, people won't recognise him." So first you meet your family and they know you, and then, miraculously, your legs and your eyesight return. Saadia brings Yeshayahu 35: **אז תפקחנה עיני עורים ואזני חרשים תפתחנה. אז ידלג כאיל פסח ותרן לשון אלם**: the eyes of the blind will open, the ears of the deaf, the lame will leap like a deer, and the tongue of the mute will sing.

What age will we be? Saadia does not discuss it. The Rabbi would assume a person's prime, perhaps the twenties and thirties mentioned in Pirkei Avot, read the week before. "I don't know what age a person will come back." A participant preferred coming back aged ten, with life ahead. "We'll see what happens... if we'll live to see it." Then you'd be too young for a husband or wife, another said, which leads to the next question.

Question 6: Will they eat, drink and marry?

ודאי כן: certainly. Like **the son of the woman of Tzarfat**, revived by **Eliyahu**, and **the son of the Shunamit**, revived by **Elisha**: **אכלו ושתו וחיו עד זמנם**, they ate and drank and lived out their time, and likely married. Saadia understands that those boys truly died and were revived; the Rabbi recalled that one of the Rishonim reads them as merely unconscious. So too us: when we are resurrected we will eat, drink, marry and have children.

Summary

Chapter 7: four rabbinic statements

1. **Seven shepherds and eight princes** (Sukkah), including Mashiach: so the dead rise **with the redemption**.

2. Whoever dies in **the seven years of Gog** will not rise: whoever eats the appetiser eats the feast.

3. Whoever **denies resurrection** will not share in it, measure for measure, like the officer who saw the plenty but did not eat.

4. The dead rise **in their shrouds**, and the tzaddikim in their clothes, which led to **Rabban Gamliel's** simple linen shrouds, still the universal custom.

Chapter 8: the first six of ten questions

1. **Who rises?** Every tzaddik and every penitent; very few of Israel will be left out. Burial in Israel is not required for Saadia.

2. **Will they die again?** No. They pass straight into Olam HaBa in an elevated, "Moshe Rabbeinu" body, which the Ramchal describes as one that simply follows the soul. The Rambam, for this very reason, has no body there at all.

3. **Is there room?** 38.4 million people would fill less than 1/150th of the earth.

4. **Will we know our families?** Yes, as we will know the shepherds and princes.

5. **Defects?** We rise with them so we can be recognised, then are healed: "I strike and I heal."

6. **Eating, drinking and marriage?** Certainly, like the children revived by Eliyahu and Elisha.

Coming Up

No shiur next week because of Shavuot. Next time: the remaining questions, **how we move to Olam HaBa**, **whether there will still be free choice**, and more, finishing the essay. Then a shiur surveying the views of the Rishonim, including the Rambam's approach, on *techiyat hametim*.

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